sacred,—just as a definite concept remains unaltered whether it is expressed by one word or another, in one language or another.

But a comprehension of this state of affairs still does not explain the nature of the characteristic features of true religious conviction. For now another question, the one of the truly fundamental significance, must be answered: Does that higher power which stands behind the religious symbols and lends them their essential significance, dwell solely in the human mind, and is it obliterated also in the moment when that mind ceases to exist, or does it stand for something more? In other words: Does God live in the soul of the believer only, or does He rule the world independently of whether or not one believes in Him? This is the point at which minds part company basically and decisively. This question can never be cleared up scientifically, by logical conclusions based on facts. The answer is solely and exclusively a matter of faith—religious faith.

The answer of the religious person is that God exists, that He existed before there were human beings on the earth, that he holds the whole world, believers as well as disbelievers, in His omnipotent hands since the beginning of eternity, and that He will continue to rule from His heights inaccessible to human imagination long after the earth and everything on it will have crumbled to dust. All those who profess this belief and, filled by it with humility and unquestioning trust and devotion, feel protected by the Almighty from every danger in life, all those—but only those—may consider themselves truly religious.

This is the essential content of creed which religion requires its followers to profess. Let us now see whether and how these requirements are compatible with those of science, natural science in particular.

III

In proceeding to examine what laws science teaches us, and what truths it considers to be inviolable, our task will be simplified and our purpose fully served by keeping to the most exact of all natural sciences, physics. For this is the branch of science which by every logic could be expected to be the most likely to conflict with the demands of religion. Therefore, we are to inquire what kind of discoveries physical science has made up to our most recent days, and what limits these might set for religious faith.

I hardly need to point out that viewed historically and on the whole, the findings of physical research and the conclusions resulting from them do not exhibit a purposeless change, but have been steadily improving in precision and completeness until the most recent days, some times at a faster at other times at a slower rate; and we therefore have every reason to regard the